SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #35 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

# “Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing.”

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## Where it often comes from

Sports, school, business, and even church ministries can teach that only winners matter. Parents who cheer wins and sulk over losses, coaches who shame mistakes, and a culture that celebrates champions make losing feel like disgrace. Fear of losing can make us avoid trying.

## What Scripture teaches

Paul uses the race as a picture: “Run in such a way as to take the prize,” and at the end of his life, “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith.” Notice he does not say, “I won every race.” Solomon observes, “The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong… For time and chance happen to all.” Paul says, “In all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us.” The psalmist says, “It is God who judges; He brings down one and exalts another.” Faithfulness, not victory, is the measure God gives.

> *“I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith”* (2 Timothy 4:7).

## Also see

> “Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize? Run in such a way as to take the prize. Everyone who competes in the games trains with strict discipline. They do it for a crown that is perishable, but we do it for a crown that is imperishable” (1 Corinthians 9:24–25).

> “I saw something else under the sun: The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong; neither is the bread to the wise, nor the wealth to the intelligent, nor the favor to the skillful. For time and chance happen to all” (Ecclesiastes 9:11).

> “No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us” (Romans 8:37).

> “For exaltation comes neither from east nor west, nor out of the desert, but it is God who judges; He brings down one and exalts another” (Psalm 75:6–7).

## Common self-statements

- If I lose, I am a loser.
- Second place is failure.
- I have to win to be valued.
- I cannot stand losing.
- Winners matter and losers do not.
- I would rather not try than lose.

## Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing outcomes as win or total loss.
- Labeling: Calling myself a loser.
- Perfectionism: Demanding victory every time.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a loss as ruin.

## Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that only winning counts?
- What have I learned from my losses?
- Who do I admire, and is it for winning or for character?
- What does faithfulness look like in my situation?
- What would I attempt if losing were not a disaster?
- What does God say about worth apart from outcomes?

## Truth summary

> My worth does not depend on winning. Faithfulness, effort, and character matter most, and God sees them. I can compete with joy, lose with grace, and be more than a conqueror through Christ's love.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Strength
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**More Than Conquerors** — Steven Curtis Chapman
Christ's saving work answers condemnation, shame, and fear of separation from God.

**Grace Wins** — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

**Greater** — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

**Victory in Jesus** — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Who taught me only wins count?
- ☐ What have I learned from losing?
- ☐ Whom do I admire?
- ☐ What is faithfulness?
- ☐ What would I try?
- ☐ What does God say?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ I can finish the race and keep the faith.
- ☐ Time and chance happen to all.
- ☐ I am more than a conqueror through Christ.
- ☐ God judges, not the scoreboard.
- ☐ Losing teaches.
- ☐ I can try without fear.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ 2 Timothy 4:7
  *"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."*
- ☐ Romans 8:37
  *"No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us."*
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 9:11
  *"I saw something else under the sun: The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong; neither is the bread to the wise, nor the wealth to the intelligent, nor the favor to the skillful. For time and chance happen to all."*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Faithful, not flawless: Each week, note one effort made and one lesson from a loss.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  *For example, 2 Timothy 4:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can finish the race and keep the faith, win or lose.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Pride" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.*

- ☐ Trace the message. Write who taught you that only winning counts.
- ☐ Debrief a loss. Write three lessons from a recent loss.
- ☐ Try something new. Do something you might not win.
- ☐ Encourage a loser. Cheer for someone who tried and lost.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing": _____ % My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Faithful, not flawless |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I fear losing. Teach me that faithfulness matters more than winning, and help me compete with joy and lose with grace, knowing Your love does not change. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*